



APPS



Pocket FM gives its writers an AI tool to transform narratives, write cliffhangers, and more

India-based audio series platform maker [Pocket FM](#) aims to be the Netflix of audio. That is, the company intends to match its audio series with hundreds of episodes to its users' tastes. For that to work, it needs to release content rapidly — something it's now turning to AI to help with.

The Lightspeed-backed startup is giving its writers an AI tool set that can do things like suggest better endings to an episode or make the narrative more engaging. The hope is that the tools will speed up the copy-writing process.

Pocket FM already uses some AI tools like [ElevenLabs](#) to generate voices for audio series. It also tested AI tools for writing and adaptation assistance internally.

Rohan Nayak, Pocket FM's founder, said it's rolling out the AI tools to all writers, so it will take them less time to finish their episodes.

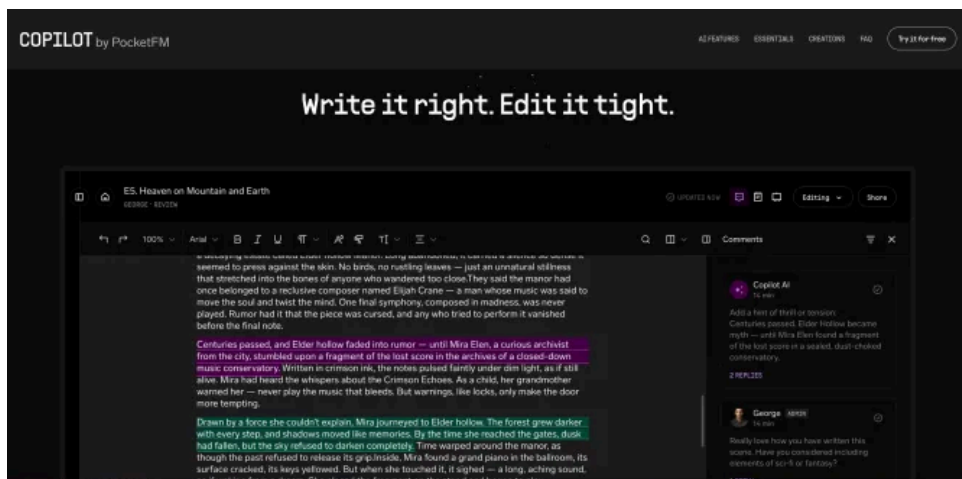


IMAGE CREDITS: POCKET FM

The writing tool, dubbed [CoPilot](#), can be used to help any writer create a story.

CoPilot can transform narrative-based writing into dialog-based writing for a specific segment. It can also do “beat analysis” to shape the writing in a way to makes it more engaging for an audio series of a particular genre. The tool additionally has basic chatbot-style writing features such as “shorten,” “expand,” and the ability to generate text via a prompt.

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To build CoPilot, the company examined thousands of hours of data points to understand what makes users engage more with a particular storyline in a specific genre.

Based on that, it added writing suggestion features designed to increase conflict between characters and recommend endings for an episode to make it more exciting. AI can also suggest tags for background effects that can be used while producing the audio.

The tool can automatically generate bios of characters, their relationships, and summarize plot points of different episodes, allowing creators to refer back to these details while writing.

CoPilot also has a review tool, which checks for plot points, grammar, and leaves qualitative feedback through comments on an episode.

Under the hood, Pocket FM is training smaller models to maintain context for a story for character arcs and relations, along with narrative consistency. Plus, utilizing signals from users, the startup is nudging AI to add more drama to the story.

International expansion and localization plans

Alongside the arrival of the AI tools, Pocket FM launched adaptation tools for various markets that not only translate the text from one language to another but also change names and phrases that are more suited to that region's culture.

The company first debuted this tool as a part of the CoPilot suite in Germany earlier this year to convert stories from other regions after reportedly [struggling to engage users in the European country last year](#).

Nayak said the company saw great results from this trial, with a constant increase in monthly in-app revenue, which crossed \$700,000 in June.

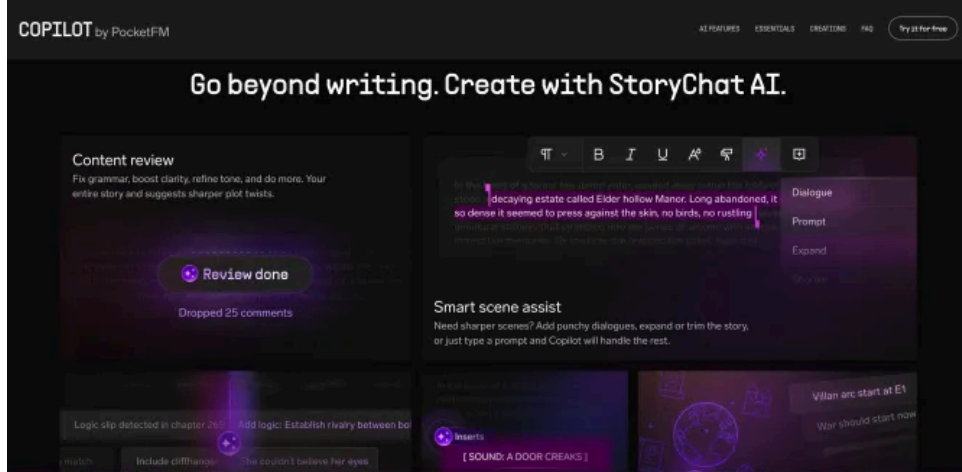


IMAGE CREDITS: POCKET FM

“When we started expanding into new regions, it used to take us 12-18 months to meaningfully exist in that market. You have to have at least 1,000 hours of content to start acquiring users and scaling the market. Now we can do this in less than three months,” Nayak said.

The tool increased writer productivity by up to 50% for the German market in terms of show output. Plus, the tool helped the company create more error-free drafts of the shows that resulted in higher user retention for audio series.

In the U.S., series created with the help of these new AI tools are now contributing 10% of playtime. Plus, these shows have generated \$7 million in revenue in the last 12 months while reducing the cost of production by 2-3 times.

Building tech to scale content generation

As a result of adopting different AI features internally, Pocket FM has been able to scale the content quickly. The startup said it launches close to 1,000 pilots per month. And just the sheer volume of content results in a few of them becoming hits.

But the audio show is just one part. The company is already working on tools to convert stories into comic strips with its [Pocket Toons](#) platform. Plus, Nayak said video is a possible format the company could explore, too. The startup, which has raised over [\\$196 million in funding across rounds](#), is experimenting with a micro drama app as well.

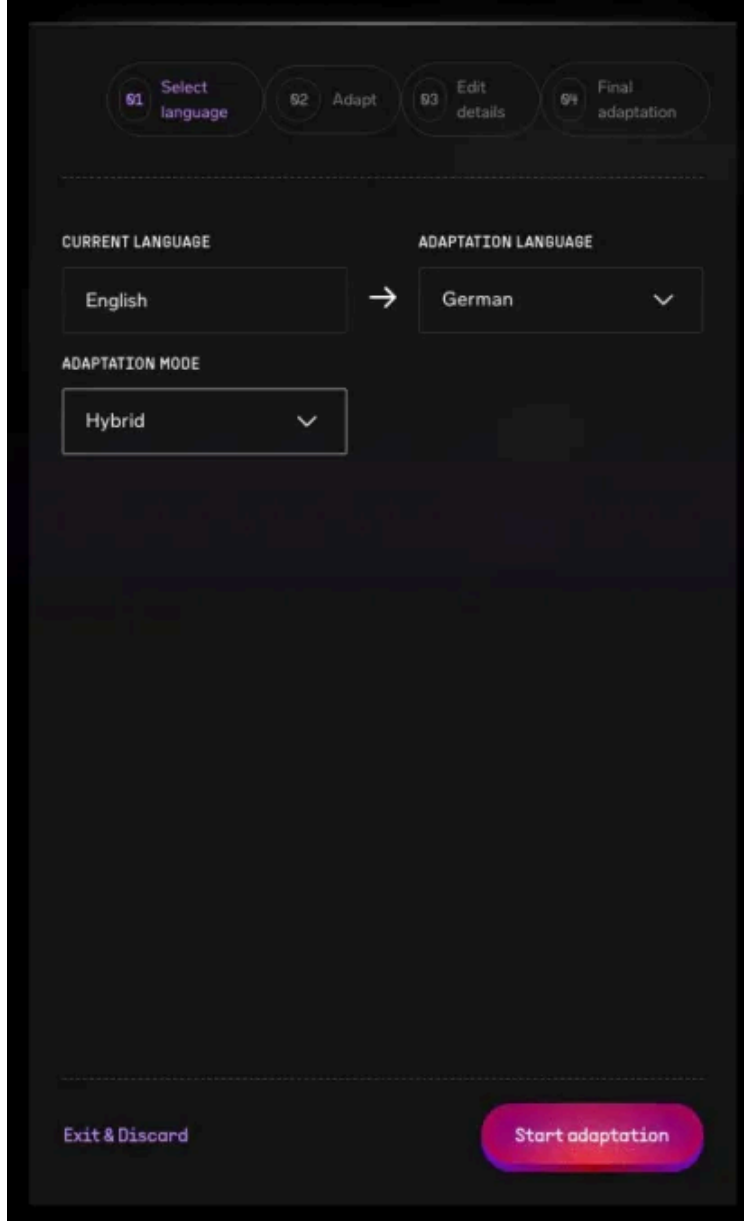


IMAGE CREDITS:TECHCRUNCH (SCREENSHOT)

By next year, Pocket FM wants to release its own singular large language model (LLM), which will be based on data collected from its shows and incorporate different tools like writing assistance, adoption, dramatization, and story context retention. The company’s co-founder, Prateek Dixit, said that when it switches to its own LLM, it won’t need to train a ton of small models for separate features.

AI’s potential downsides

Adopting AI has had its side effects.

Pocket FM has already laid off people who were employees or contractors [across multiple rounds](#) in the last 12 months. There have also been reports of writers seeing [diminished returns](#) over time. And the company is facing [lawsuits in California over employment and wage issues](#).

“Like most content-led industries, we work with a diverse network of writers, voice artists, and production partners on a project basis, tailoring resources to each market. AI has had minimal impact on our core creative community; instead, it has opened new avenues to expand reach and output,” a company rep said, in response to these layoffs.

There are questions around quality, as well. The company measures quality by the retention numbers of a show.

The base argument is that the new AI tools act as a writers’ room even for solo creators, so they will be able to produce more content at a rapid rate. Plus, based on the numbers, writers can quickly edit the story with the help of AI. However, these tools can very well induce “AI slop” — or low-quality, AI-generated content — into the platform and could impact a user’s recommendations, making it difficult for them to discover good stories.

Pocket FM argues that stories that have a solid structure will gain popularity, despite AI helping them.

The company noted that every piece of content is reviewed by its AI-powered moderation framework to ensure quality and originality. It also claims its AI moderation checks for things like duplication, copyright issues, content health, and other quality measures before approving audio to go live. Each show receives an equal push, and user engagement ultimately determines a show’s ranking.

Another concern is that writers could become overly dependent on AI over time.

In Germany, AI is writing more content than humans per show for select titles. With Pocket FM’s plans to roll out more AI tools, the amount of AI-written content could increase. And with that, the expectation of churning out more shows could rise, too. Unless user adoption also rises rapidly, average returns could drop.

The company didn’t directly address TechCrunch’s questions about returns, but said that its AI tools can speed up a writer’s work and help them edit an episode based on numbers and audience feedback. That is they could make targeted improvements, instead of doing a full rewrite.

“This way, faster content creation doesn’t necessarily dilute quality or relevance; it just shifts the writer’s role towards editing, refining, and steering more productive output,” a spokesperson said in a statement.

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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously worked at publications including...

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Grammarly gets a design overhaul, multiple AI features

Grammarly now has a new document-based interface, built on the [back of Coda, the productivity startup it acquired last year](#). The interface also sports an AI assistant, as well as a few AI tools meant for students and professionals, including an AI grader, proofreader, and citation finder.

The new interface adopts a block-first approach, letting you insert tables, columns, separators, lists, and headers. You also can add rich text blocks to highlight information and add tips or alerts.

A sidebar hosts the AI assistant, which can summarize text, answer your questions, and provide writing suggestions.

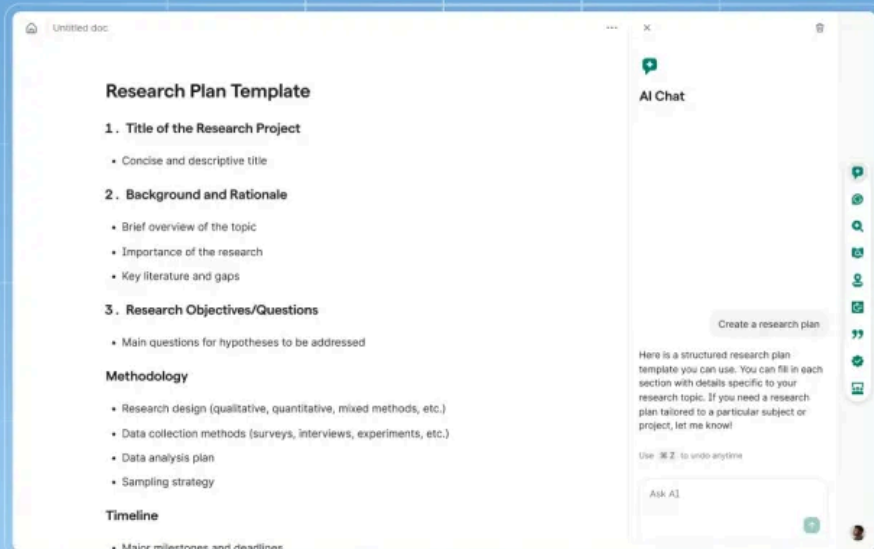


IMAGE CREDITS: GRAMMARLY

There are a bunch of AI tools, too: “Reader Reactions” lets you to pick a reader persona and get feedback on your writing

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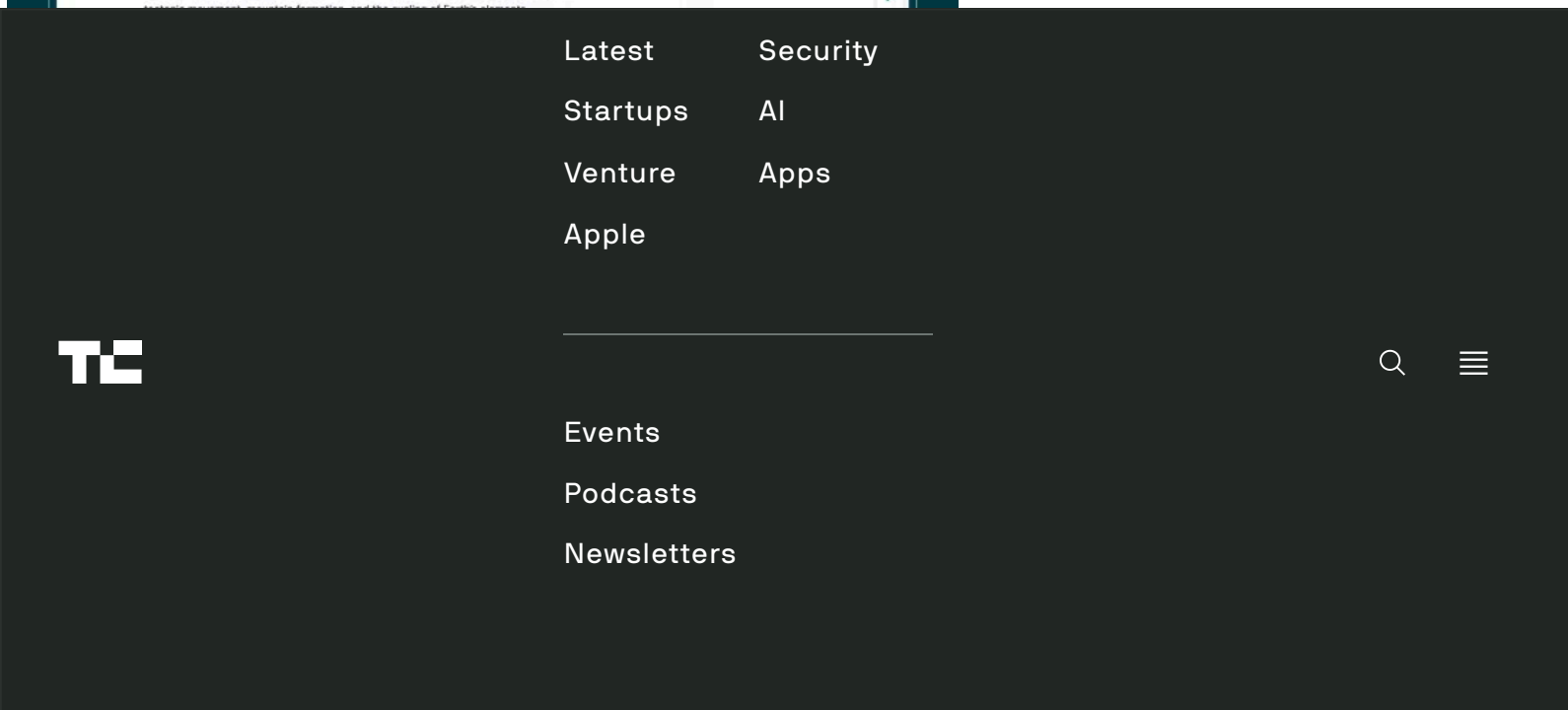
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based on that persona; “Grader” can provide feedback based on an instructor’s guidelines and publicly available course material; “Citation Finder,” like it says on the tin, can help you find and generate citations from public materials; and “Paraphraser” can modify a text’s tone according to your preferences.

Grammarly’s also added agents that can detect plagiarism or AI-generated content.



to TechCrunch that agents made to detect AI-generated content can be hit or miss, but he claimed that the company has tuned its agent to be the most accurate in the market.

“The goal here is not to provide an enforcement mechanism for teachers. If teachers want to enforce policies, they should use our authorship tool. But this [AI detector tool] is about providing a window to students into what could be AI-generated text in their writing before they submit,” he told TechCrunch.

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Taken as a whole, Grammarly now has tools that can help students write using AI, *and also* detect AI-generated writing. So how is it striking a balance between those foci, which one could argue are at opposite ends of the spectrum? Well, the company says it has “a moral imperative” to teach students how to use AI and make them ready for the workforce.

Like many other companies these days, Grammarly wants to build and integrate more AI agents in its products — the company essentially said as much when it [announced the acquisition of email client Superhuman last month](#).

In May, Grammarly raised \$1 billion from General Catalyst to make acquisitions and [bolster its sales and marketing efforts](#).

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Ivan Mehta

X in

Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously worked at publications including...

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Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

Latest in Startups

"I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing," Monaco told TechCrunch. "But it was actually a pain to maintain. There's so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs."

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google's Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

"We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs," Monaco said. "It's just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users."

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company's "extremely aggressive product roadmap."

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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn't the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn't really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn't think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I'm seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That's the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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